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Local competitive authoritarianism and post-conflict violence. An analysis of the assassination of social leaders in Colombia

Juan Albarracín^a , Juan Pablo Milanese^b , Inge H. Valencia^b , and Jonas Wolff^c 

^aUniversity of Illinois Chicago; ^bUniversidad Icesi; ^cGoethe University Frankfurt & Peace Research Institute Frankfurt (PRIF)

ABSTRACT

The threat of continued violence is a primary concern in post-conflict societies. This article contributes to the literature on post-conflict violence by analyzing a specific phenomenon that has characterized Colombia since the signing of the 2016 peace agreement: the assassination of social leaders. Building on explanations that emphasize state weakness, illicit economies, and the role of illegal armed actors, we argue that the assassination of social leaders also responds to efforts by local elites to sustain local competitive authoritarian orders in the face of bottom-up threats to their power by sociopolitical actors mobilized around the local implementation of the peace agreement. Using a cross-sectional dataset of Colombian municipalities, we find that assassinations of social leaders are more likely and more frequent in municipalities with intermediate levels of party fragmentation and low levels of voter turnout—that is, in municipalities with restricted electoral competition. Furthermore, a higher share of votes for leftist parties, which signals the presence of challengers to local elites, correlates with a higher probability and a higher number of assassinations. Overall, this article suggests that the nature of local political orders constitutes a key dimension shaping the micro-dynamics of violence and repression in post-conflict contexts.

La amenaza de la continuación de la violencia es una de las principales preocupaciones en las sociedades en posconflicto. Este artículo contribuye a la literatura sobre la violencia en el posconflicto analizando un fenómeno específico que ha caracterizado a Colombia desde la firma del acuerdo de paz de 2016: el asesinato de líderes sociales. Partiendo de las explicaciones que enfatizan la debilidad del Estado, las economías ilícitas y el papel de los actores armados ilegales, argumentamos que el asesinato de líderes sociales también responde a los esfuerzos de las élites locales para sostener los órdenes autoritarios competitivos locales frente a las amenazas a su poder por parte de los actores sociopolíticos movilizados en torno a la implementación local del acuerdo de paz.

KEYWORDS

Colombia; competitive authoritarianism; local politics; post-conflict violence; repression

CONTACT Juan Albarracín  jgalba@uic.edu  Department of Political Science, University of Illinois Chicago, 1007 West Harrison St. – 1110 BSB, Chicago, IL 60607, USA

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Utilizando un conjunto de datos de municipios colombianos, observamos que los asesinatos de líderes sociales son más probables y más frecuentes en municipios con niveles intermedios de fragmentación partidista y bajos niveles de participación electoral, es decir, en municipios con competencia electoral restringida. Además, se correlaciona una mayor proporción de votos a los partidos de izquierda, un indicador de la presencia de contendientes a las élites locales, con una mayor probabilidad de que ocurran asesinatos, así como un mayor número de casos. Como conclusión, este artículo sugiere que la naturaleza de los órdenes políticos locales constituye una dimensión clave que determina las microdinámicas de la violencia y la represión en contextos de posconflicto.

Le risque de la poursuite des violences est une préoccupation majeure dans les sociétés post-conflit. Cet article contribue à la littérature sur la violence post-conflit en analysant un phénomène spécifique qui caractérise la Colombie depuis la signature de l'accord de paix de 2016 : l'assassinat de leaders sociaux. En s'appuyant sur des explications qui mettent l'accent sur la faiblesse de l'État, les économies illicites et le rôle des acteurs armés illégaux, nous soutenons que l'assassinat des leaders sociaux répond également aux efforts des élites locales pour maintenir des ordres autoritaires compétitifs locaux face aux menaces à leur pouvoir de la part des acteurs sociopolitiques mobilisés autour de la mise en œuvre locale de l'accord de paix. En utilisant des données provenant de municipalités colombiennes, nous constatons que les assassinats de leaders sociaux sont plus probables et plus fréquents dans les municipalités où la concurrence électorale est limitée. En outre, une part plus importante de votes pour les partis de gauche, un indicateur de la présence de concurrents (challengers) aux élites locales, est corrélée à une plus grande probabilité d'assassinats, ainsi qu'à un nombre plus élevé de cas. En conclusion, cet article suggère que la nature des ordres politiques locaux constitue une dimension clé déterminant la micro-dynamique de la violence et de la répression dans les contextes post-conflit.

Introduction

The threat of continued violence is a primary concern in post-conflict societies. Civil war recurrence is a common phenomenon (Call 2012), as is the remilitarization of demobilized armed groups (Daly 2016) and an increase in overall levels of public insecurity (Steenkamp 2011). While our understanding of conflict recurrence has advanced considerably (Daly 2016; Steinert, Steinert, and Carey 2019, among others), other forms of post-conflict violence have received much less attention (Grandi 2013). What is more, forms of violence that do not simply reflect a continuation or recurrence of the (past) armed conflict are often primarily analyzed as “criminal” violence, suggesting a turn from the political

logic of war to an allegedly purely economic logic of organized crime (Kurtenbach and Rettberg 2018; Steenkamp 2011).

The targeted violence against social leaders that Colombia has experienced since the 2016 peace agreement is a case in point. While the peace process with the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC) has been accompanied by a historical decline in the homicide rate, as well as in most indicators of organized violence, the number of assassinations of social leaders has seen a marked increase (Ávila 2020, 55; Gutiérrez Sanín et al. 2020; Holmes and Pavon-Harr 2019; Prem et al. 2021). In line with established findings from the study of war-to-peace-transitions (see, for example, Kurtenbach and Rettberg 2018, 4), scholars, government officials, and media outlets have tried to account for this phenomenon by emphasizing the role of non-state armed groups (NSAGs),¹ which have taken advantage of the territorial power vacuums generated by the demobilization of the FARC and killed social leaders in their fight over the control of illicit economies (Prem et al. 2021, 3).²

As we show in this article, this predominant narrative offers important clues to explain the spatial distribution of assassinated leaders across Colombia's over 1,100 municipalities. Yet, by focusing narrowly on criminal structures and illegal actors, this explanation misses a decidedly political dimension of the phenomenon at hand: The manner in which political competition plays out at the local level also significantly impacts the likelihood that social leaders will be assassinated in a given municipality in post-agreement Colombia. More specifically, we suggest that the targeted violence against social leaders also responds to efforts by entrenched subnational elites to maintain local competitive authoritarian orders in the face of bottom-up challenges to their power that have emerged in the context of the peace process. The 2016 agreement has not only come with the demobilization of the FARC, but also has contributed to shifts in the political correlation of forces and to an upturn in social activism at the local level, in response to the peace accord's promise of bringing social and political reforms to Colombia's peripheral regions (Gutiérrez Sanín et al. 2020, 37–38; ICG [International Crisis Group] 2020, 13–14; Prem et al. 2021, 10). The assassination of social leaders, thus, aims not only at gaining or preserving the control over illicit economies, but also—and frequently simultaneously—at sustaining competitive authoritarian local orders in the face of bottom-up challenges.

¹The category “non-state armed groups” (NSAGs) encompasses all actors that do not belong to the state but use organized violence and exert some level of territorial control. In Colombia, this includes both guerrilla and neo-paramilitary groups as well as more “clearly” criminal organizations.

²See also Defensoría del Pueblo (2017) and ICG (2020) as well as, for the case of Tumaco, Salas Salazar, Wolff, and Camelo (2019). A related explanation focuses on the collapse of forms of rebel governance or illegal protection as causes of violence after demobilization (Nussio and Howe 2016).

To assess our theory, we use a cross-sectional dataset of Colombian municipalities to explore if the occurrence and frequency of assassinations of social leaders³ are associated with key characteristics of local political competition. We find that a higher share of vote for leftist parties before the peace agreement—which in Colombia’s rural municipalities reliably indicates the existence of powerful social movements (Carroll 2011, 43) and thus a challenge to local elites—is associated with higher probability and frequency of assassinations of social leaders. We also observe that assassinations of social leaders are more likely and, on average, more frequent in municipalities with low electoral turnout—which we interpret to be settings with restricted participation. Moreover, the occurrence and frequency of killings of social leaders exhibits a curvilinear relationship with the degree of political competition. Assassinations tend to occur (and more frequently so) in municipalities with moderately concentrated local party systems—which we interpret to be settings of restricted, but still existing electoral competition. In sum, these findings indicate that targeted, lethal violence against social leaders in post-agreement Colombia also has decidedly political underpinnings.

The aim of this paper is to explain the specific wave of assassinations of social leaders in contemporary Colombia since the peace agreement—a topic that is both of great interest for the academic scholarship on post-conflict violence and of high political relevance. Our theory and findings, however, also provide valuable contributions to broader academic debates. Research on civic space restrictions and the repression of civil society actors identifies similar patterns of targeted physical violence, including killing activists, often seen as specific manifestation—the “tip of the iceberg” (Le Billon and Lujala 2020, 5, see also Middeldorp and Le Billon 2019)—of a broader repertoire of repression that civil society actors face in many countries around the world (Glasius, Schalk, and De Lange 2020; Navas, Mingorria, and Aguilar-González 2018). Analyzing various causes and consequences of restrictions on civil society actors, this scholarship so far mainly focuses on the national level (Bakke, Mitchell, and Smidt 2020; Dupuy, Ron, and Prakash 2016; Glasius, Schalk, and De Lange 2020). Our analysis of a systematic, but more decentralized form of violence against civil society actors enriches this literature by analyzing the local conditions under which democratizing processes provoke attempts (by local elites and NSAGs) to effectively close civic space through targeted violence against social leaders.

³Throughout the article, occurrence refers to the question whether any assassination of a social leader has been observed in a given municipality; frequency, in contrast, refers to the number of assassinations per municipality.

Our research also contributes to existing studies on the relationship between regime type and political repression or post-conflict violence, which also has so far predominantly focused on the national level. In line with studies on civic space restrictions and the actual killings of activists as cited above, this scholarship has emphasized the peculiar risk of violence in political regimes of an intermediate type (whether conceptualized as illiberal, semi-authoritarian or hybrid) as well as in contexts of political change (democratization and/or war-to-peace transitions; see, e.g. Davenport 2007; Doorenspleet 2019, 129–133). We argue that a similar relationship may be operating at the subnational level, bringing the question of regime type or political order to the study of the micro-dynamics of post-conflict violence (Autesserre 2006). We do so by applying Levitsky and Way's (2010) concept of competitive authoritarian regimes to the local level, showing that targeted violence against social leaders in post-agreement Colombia is more likely in municipalities characterized by local competitive authoritarianism—i.e. municipalities in which local elites concentrate political power, informally subverting democratic processes, which they cannot, however, suspend entirely. We expand our knowledge of the relationship between regime type and violence by focusing on how hegemonic local elites' responses to challenges to their entrenched power “from below” target highly visible and particularly vulnerable social leaders as a means to prevent anti-elite groups and forces from gaining political ground. While the assassination of social leaders is, in many ways, a Colombia-specific phenomenon, the application of the competitive authoritarianism framework to the subnational level offers a theoretical framework that may also help understand decentralized forms of violence in post-conflict settings and beyond.

The Assassination of Social Leaders in Post-Conflict Colombia

The current wave of targeted assassinations of social leaders in Colombia is a post-conflict phenomenon, analytically different from the violence against civilians observed during the civil war (Kalyvas 2006; for the Colombian case see Moreno 2017, among others). Following Boyle (2009), we argue that this observed form of violence against social leaders generally responds to changing opportunities, incentives and threats brought about by a given peace process. Empirically distinguishing between civil war and post-conflict violence is notoriously difficult since the two often coexist. In Colombia, in particular, the existence of various NSAGs and the failure to include all of them in one all-encompassing peace process has meant that even the successful demobilization of one group merely ended this specific armed conflict, while other NSAGs remained in violent confrontation with

the state (Carroll 2011, 4–22). But still, it is notable that waves of assassinations of social (and political) leaders in the country have typically occurred during or after peace processes (CINEP et al. 2018). For example, after the (ultimately failed) negotiations between the Betancur government and the FARC in the 1980s led to the establishment of the *Unión Patriótica* (UP) party, representatives and members of this party were systematically assassinated. UP militants were targeted by a coalition of local elites, NSAGs and some members of the armed forces, particularly as the UP was increasingly successful in local elections (Carroll 2011; Romero 2003; Steele 2017). A similar pattern of violence was observed in the wake of the 1991 peace agreement with the smaller *Partido Revolucionario de los Trabajadores* (Mercado Vega 2022).

Unfortunately, we now observe a similar trend. Between 2016 and 2020, an estimated 1,227 social leaders were assassinated in Colombia, according to the human rights NGO Indepaz (2022). The exact numbers vary depending on the reporting source, mostly due to different definitions of who, exactly, qualifies as a social leader and whether their murder is acknowledged to be related to their activism.⁴ However, regardless of source, the number of assassinations grew between 2016 and 2020. Moreover, there is also considerable spatial variation in the occurrence and frequency of lethal violence against social leaders. Although this form of violence can be observed across the country and in a plurality of *departamentos* (provinces), it tends to be concentrated in some municipalities (e.g. Tumaco) and *departamentos* (e.g. Cauca).

The current targets of post-conflict violence are usually referred to in Colombia as “social leaders” (*líderes sociales*). In its current usage in Colombia, the concept encompasses a wide range of sociopolitical activists and civic leaders, including representatives of local community organizations (e.g. *Juntas de Acción Comunal*, or Local Community Boards), leaders of indigenous, Afro-Colombian and peasant organizations, labor leaders and human rights defenders. Although they are public actors linked to civil society organizations, social leaders also repeatedly play an active role in party politics running as candidates in local elections. While not associated with one specific party in Colombia’s fragmented party system, social movements and their leaders in rural Colombia often build the base and leadership of local leftist parties, as they did so in the past (see Carroll 2011, 43).

As it has been observed in other countries, we often know little about the actual “mastermind” of violence against civil society actors, as in many

⁴Such discrepancies between sources are not unusual in violence data. These differences can be used to estimate the population of assassinations, as Rozo Ángel and Ball (2019) have done. These estimations show that most sources (except Indepaz) tend to underreport assassinations.

cases the perpetrators act as “intermediaries” used by political actors (or private companies) to carry out the “more insidious forms of repression” (Middeldorp and Le Billon 2019, 328–329). In fact, as Le Billon and Lujala argue, the very “anonymity and/or impunity of perpetrators often result from the modus operandi of killings (e.g. hired gunmen), participation or complicity and cover-ups by authorities and local elites in the killings” (2020, 6). In Colombia, little information exists about the direct perpetrators. According to Indepaz (2022), perpetrators remained unknown in 78% of cases, while paramilitary and criminal groups were identified as presumed perpetrators in about 14% of cases, the ELN and other guerrilla groups in 2% of cases, and state security forces in 4.5% of cases. For previous waves of targeted violence in Colombia, like the assassination of UP and PRT members, we now have direct evidence of the involvement of local political and socio-economic elites, as well as of state security forces, in the killings (Mercado Vega 2022). This information was available decades later, often through transitional justice processes. For the current context, however, evidence from certain municipalities strongly suggests that, at least in some parts of the country, local elites—large landowners, (former) representatives of municipal or regional governments as well as influential local politicians and businesspersons—have been involved in organizing violent resistance against “pro-peace policies” (Gutiérrez Sanín et al. 2020, 27–31, 37–42) and/or implicated in the assassination of social leaders (Albarracín et al. 2022, 15–19; Ávila 2020, 69–70, 120–25, 267–324).

Unlike other cases of state restrictions on civil society actors (e.g. Glasius, Schalk, and De Lange 2020; Dupuy, Ron, and Prakash 2016), the assassination of social leaders in Colombia does not respond to a centralized strategy of repression by the national state. As we will discuss later, it is facilitated by certain characteristics of state presence and the glaring indifference of the national government that enables localized actors (NSAGs and local elites) to perpetrate this type of violence. The fact that the targets of the current wave of post-conflict violence are more diverse and fragmented than past case like the *Unión Patriótica*, does not imply that it is not systematic. Generally speaking, the victims during the contemporary cycle are leaders associated with the implementation of “pro-peace policies,” such as land restitution, coca substitution, or local participatory development programs (Gutiérrez Sanín et al. 2020). The fact that the number of assassinations has increased, and significantly so, while virtually all other indicators of violence have diminished (Gutiérrez Sanín et al. 2020, 7; Holmes and Pavon-Harr 2019, 135–37), also supports the notion that we are dealing here with a phenomenon that reflects the peculiarities of an (attempted) war-to-peace transition (see also Prem et al. 2021, 10–12).

Beyond Illicit Markets and State Incapacity: The Political Logic of Post-Conflict Violence

While observers agree that the current wave of assassinations of social leaders in Colombia is related to the 2016 peace agreement, they disagree about the precise causes.⁵ However, the main arguments put forward suggest an explanation that emphasizes the actions and interactions of armed and/or criminal actors in contexts characterized by thriving illegal economies and a precarious state presence (see Defensoría del Pueblo 2017; CINEP et al. 2018; ICG [International Crisis Group] 2020; Prem et al. 2021; UNHCHR 2019).⁶ These dynamics are depicted as particularly pronounced in territories that previously had been controlled by the FARC. While this explanation identifies important factors that shape lethal violence against social leaders, we suggest it misses an important part of the story: the nature of local political orders in the context of limited state presence and thriving illicit economies, which profoundly influences this specific form of violence.

Illegal Economies, the Presence of Non-State Armed Groups, and State Capacity

The conventional explanation emphasizes three factors that together have produced the recent wave of assassinations of social leaders. First, the assassinations are seen as a result of the interrelated expansion of illegal economies and criminal and/or armed groups, which can be observed in quite a few regions in post-agreement Colombia (Salas Salazar, Wolff, and Camelo 2019; Defensoría del Pueblo 2017). While the transformation from political to criminal violence is well known from the study of war-to-peace transitions, in contemporary Colombia this dynamic is aggravated by the fact the 2016 peace agreement only included one out of several NSAGs (Prem et al. 2021). As a result, both pre-existing NSAGs and the newly emerged so-called FARC dissident groups struggle over the control of lucrative illicit markets, such as illegal mining and drug trafficking. In this context, social leaders are assassinated in order to intimidate and demobilize local communities and social movements that claim human rights, defend access to land, engage in alternative socioeconomic development projects or simply resist being extorted (CINEP et al. 2018; UNHCHR 2019). In this sense, we should expect more assassinations of social leaders in municipalities with a

⁵The most systematic, academic attempts to analyze the phenomenon at hand, include Ávila (2020), Gutiérrez Sanín et al. (2020), Holmes and Pavon-Harr (2019), as well as Prem et al. (2021). Policy-oriented reports include Stiftung (2018), CINEP et al. (2018), ICG (2020), and UNHCHR (2019).

⁶Similar explanations also have been advanced by state officials and media outlets (see, for instance, Presidencia de la República 2020).

greater density of illegal economies and presence of non-state armed groups.

The second factor concerns the “power vacuum” that has emerged in areas previously controlled by the FARC and enabled the above-mentioned expansion of illicit economies and competing NSAGs (ICG [International Crisis Group] 2020, 11; Prem et al. 2021; Salas Salazar, Wolff, and Camelo 2019). The demobilization of the FARC meant the dissolution of forms of rebel governance established by this group in peripheral areas (Arjona 2016). As has been shown in previous research, the collapse of “monopolistic illegal protection systems” (Nussio and Howe 2016) in the context of demobilization processes can increase violence as old and new NSAGs compete for territorial control. We should, therefore, observe higher levels of assassinations of social leaders in municipalities with FARC presence before the peace agreement.

The peace agreement envisioned a stronger presence of the state precisely in peripheral areas, for example, through special, community-based development plans (Programs for Development with a Territorial Focus—PDET), rural development and illicit crop substitution programs, as well as through effective security guarantees for ex-combatants and local communities. Yet, as most observers agree, this promise has mostly failed to materialize. Assassinations are thus more likely because the Colombian state lacks the capacity and/or the political will to effectively protect social leaders in the regions at hand (Holmes and Pavon-Harr 2019; ICG [International Crisis Group] 2020). While a previous FARC presence in a given municipality already indicates a structurally weak state presence, we also should expect (higher numbers of) assassinations of social leaders in municipalities characterized by low state capacity.

Competitive Authoritarianism, Bottom-Up Challenges to Local Elites, and Violence

Colombia’s state-building process has led to a strong variation of state capacity across the country. This is indeed an important condition that enables violence to occur in the country’s peripheries, but does not explain by itself the dynamics of lethal violence observed against social leaders (Holmes and Pavon-Harr 2019). It is necessary to explore how this form of state presence also profoundly shaped the ways in which local political orders work in the more peripheral regions.

Historically, the central state informally delegated upon local elites the political and social control of subnational areas in exchange for their allegiance. In this way, the Colombian state did not have to incur the costs of state-building in the periphery, while maintaining its stability. Most of the

resulting local sociopolitical orders were highly exclusionary, reflecting the preferences of local elites (González and Otero 2010; Robinson 2013). In many of these peripheral areas, following Pearce's logic of "perverse state formation" (Pearce 2010), local elites were later substituted by criminal groups, cooperated with them, or created their own para-military/criminal groups. In this sense, it is difficult to draw distinctions between criminal groups and local political elites in the periphery, as the latter are often closely linked to illicit markets. In the Cauca province, for example, "many mayors of the region have backhoes extracting gold illegally and they are shielded by illegal security schemes [...]"⁷ The specific character of local elites varies across the country. Some are landowners producing licit products (e.g. cattle); others are more directly engaged in illegal economies (Carroll 2011; Gutiérrez Sanín 2014; Mercado Vega 2022). They have in common their direct or indirect control of local governments, which is oftentimes sustained through "regional violent coalitions" (Gómez-Suárez 2013) with NSAGs.

These alliances do not only engage in illicit activities, but effectively govern and provide public goods (e.g. security, dispute settlement) that the central state is unable or unwilling to offer (Duncan 2014). As a social leader highlighted: "the great majority of the alliances between politicians and criminal sectors [groups] revolves around taking over local power, to control city government [*alcaldías*] or city councils; this is done through armed actors."⁸ Since political power in the periphery provides access to licit and illicit sources of income for local elites, electoral politics is a high stakes game.⁹ Losing political office in elections has consequences beyond the formal loss of office. Preventing challengers from gaining control of local government through the use of violence is frequent (Carroll 2011; Mercado Vega 2022), in particular in a context where a politician can easily hire non-state armed actors and impunity is extremely high.

Thus, forms of local governance in some Colombian peripheral municipalities are often exclusionary and authoritarian. As in Gibson's (2013) analysis of subnational authoritarianism in democratic countries, subnational actors subvert formal democratic rules (Eaton and Prieto 2017). However, in contrast to the federal democracies analyzed by Gibson, in contemporary Colombia, they do so in partially different ways. In Colombia's decentralized but unitary system, subnational political actors (governors, mayors, local political machines) cannot change formal institutions in ways that

⁷Interview with social leader "A", Cauca province, April 2020.

⁸Interview with social leader "A", Cauca province, April 2020.

⁹Similar behavior was observed from insurgent groups vis-à-vis local government authorities. For example, the growing size of municipal resources that resulted from Colombia's decentralization process of the 1980s and early 1990s created incentives for insurgents' groups to target local officials (Eaton 2006).

would enable them to create uneven playing fields and restrict access to municipal government. Formally, therefore, local political orders operate according to the democratic norms of free and fair competition and open and inclusive political participation. In order to uphold their control over local government, elites influence electoral outcomes through informal mechanisms. In addition to well-known informal institutions, such as clientelism, the use of violence has historically played a key role in this regard (Acemoglu, Robinson, and Santos 2013; González and Otero 2010; Gutiérrez Sanín 2014; Nieto-Matiz 2019; Romero 2003; Steele 2017).

In order to theoretically grasp this phenomenon, we draw on the concept of competitive authoritarianism, introduced by Levitsky and Way (2010), in which formally established democratic institutions are undermined to an extent that electoral competition becomes highly unfair. In fact, Levitsky and Way's conceptualization, even if referring to the national level, precisely captures what we can observe at the subnational level in parts of Colombia. Formally, democratic institutions are in place, enabling the existence and operation of opposition parties and a wide range of civil society actors. Yet, *de facto*, elites abuse their power in order to systematically limit access to local government, constrain civic space and heavily skew the political playing field (Levitsky and Way 2010, 5–13). Given the formally democratic rules, incumbents particularly rely on informal means of control and coercion, including the use of “informal or ‘privatized’ violence to suppress opposition” (Levitsky and Way 2010, 28).¹⁰ As emphasized above, this use of informal and violent means of control and coercion becomes particularly relevant when—as in the case of Colombia's local competitive authoritarianism—municipal incumbents and elites are in principle unable to adapt the formal rules to their advantage.

We suggest that the assassination of social leaders in post-agreement Colombia—at least in part—reflects the responses of local elites who (used to) control municipal competitive authoritarian orders and face bottom-up challenges to their power in the context of the peace process. This argument is in line with research on the repression of environmental and land defenders, which has found a “curvilinear relationship” between regime type and the number of killings, while also finding evidence that challenges in the form of mass protests are associated with higher numbers of assassination (Le Billon and Lujala 2020, 10). Focusing on political assassinations, Perliger has similarly argued that electoral competition, “especially in nonliberal settings and in polarized societies,” creates incentives for

¹⁰The authors here refer to Philip Roessler who has defined privatized state violence as a subset of state violence that “is orchestrated by the state against real or perceived opponents but carried out by nonstate actors, such as vigilantes, paramilitaries, and militias, who are directly or indirectly supported by the government.” (Roessler 2005, 209; see Levitsky and Way 2010, 28).

incumbents “to find alternative ways to block opposition groups’ political influence, including the utilization of assassinations” (Perliger 2017, 697–698).

The first element of our explanation concerns the existence of local political orders that are de facto authoritarian, but still competitive to a meaningful degree. In municipalities in which political competition is relatively open and subnational elites have not managed or not even tried to seriously thwart democratic processes (in particular elections), we should observe less assassinations of social leaders. While criminal groups still might be present in such municipalities, their use of violence will be limited to the control of and competition over illicit markets. In contrast, when competitive local authoritarianism is the prevalent form of local politics, the use of violence is an important mechanism to factually restrict both political participation and competition in order to prevent rivals from winning elections and, more generally, to obstruct meaningful challenges to elite power from marginalized groups.

Theoretically, we would therefore expect a higher number of assassinations to occur in municipalities with low levels of political participation and restricted—but existing—competition. In these areas, local elites are interested in maintaining a restricted form of political participation in which some residents loyal to them vote, while supporters of challengers are deterred from participating.¹¹ Furthermore, the relationship between competition and assassinations should be curvilinear, with the risk of assassinations being relatively low in both the most authoritarian and the most democratic settings. Yet, given that Colombia’s formal democratic rules prevent the existence of fully authoritarian regimes, our set of cases does not empirically cover the entire range of the inverted U-shaped curve.

The second crucial element of our explanation focuses more specifically on the local consequences of peace agreements and, in particular, the direct threat these pose to local elites by emboldening potential challengers. While many peace agreements are negotiated at the national level, their implementation, knowingly or unknowingly, impact local power equilibria, for example, by introducing measures (redistribution, political inclusion) that strengthen challengers and therefore change the relative power between them and established elites. When impunity is high and the probability of punishment correspondingly low, local elites will resort to violence, including but not limited to the assassination of challengers, as a way to preempt their power loss.

¹¹Moreover, the assassination of social leaders, like in other cases across the globe (Ley 2018), serves to deter future political participation and thus consolidate local competitive authoritarianism. We do not develop this aspect further, as it refers to more dynamic effects of local competitive authoritarianism.

In Colombia, the 2016 peace agreement not only addressed the demobilization of FARC combatants, their socio-economic and political reintegration, and transitional justice mechanisms. It also had an explicit focus in fostering “territorial peace,” i.e. the enactment of measures promoting socio-economic and political inclusion in the country’s peripheries. This had repercussions for local orders. Agrarian development and land restitution, participatory development projects in regions highly affected by armed conflict (so-called PDET zones), and alternative coca-crop substitution programs (National Program for the Integral Substitution of Illicit Crops – PNIS) have both motivated social movements and leftist politicians to mobilize and seek to occupy spaces of local power, while limiting established elites’ control over municipal governments’ resources and their influence over illegal economies.

In a context in which the state is unwilling and/or unable to guarantee the safety of social movement leaders, while the cost of using violence is low,¹² the more credible these challenges are, the more likely local elites and their armed allies will resort to assassinations to “contain” a challenger. The electoral performance of leftist parties in Colombia offers a meaningful indicator of the strength of such local bottom-up challengers to elite power, including the existence of “powerful social movements” (Carroll 2011, 43). Therefore, we expect to see (more) assassinations of social leaders in municipalities with high support for leftist parties.

Method and Data

To assess our theory, we use a cross-sectional dataset of Colombian municipalities to explore if the two components of our explanation—the existence of local competitive authoritarianism and the presence of credible challengers to local elites—are associated with the occurrence and frequency of lethal violence against social leaders. In line with the conventional explanation, we also include indicators for state capacity, the presence of illicit economies, and non-state armed actors in our models. The point, however, is not to test the two explanations—as competing theories—against each other. As emphasized above, we consider that our theory emphasizes an additional, explicitly political dimension of the phenomenon at hand and, in this sense, complements, rather than competes with, previous explanations.

¹²In a literal sense, having a social leader assassinated is astonishingly cheap in Colombia and can cost, according to the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights defenders, as little as 100 US dollars (Reuters 2018). In addition, the probability of being punished is also very low. Until recently, there have been few convictions for the assassination of a social leader (El Espectador 2020).

Data

Dependent variable

We focus on the most visible, lethal form of violence against social leaders: assassination. Social leaders are subjected to other forms of violence, like threats and forced displacement. However, data on these is difficult to register systematically. A first variable measures the *occurrence of assassinations* in each Colombian municipality. We create a dummy variable in which 1 means that at least one assassination happened in the municipality between 2016 and 2019; zero indicates that no assassination was observed. We further measure the *frequency of assassinations* by counting all the assassinations of social leaders that occurred in a municipality in the same time frame. Data for these variables was obtained from the listing of assassinated social leaders compiled by Indepaz (2022). When estimating our models, we use logistic regression for our first—binary—dependent variable (the occurrence or not of assassinations of social leaders). For our second dependent variable, the count of assassinations in every municipality, we use a negative binomial regression model.¹³

Independent variables

A central point of our analysis is how the presence of credible challengers to existing local orders unleashes violent containment strategies by local political elites. Historically in Colombia, leftist parties have suffered from violent backlashes as they have become more successful in elections (Romero 2003; Steele 2017). At the local level, leftist parties are constituted or supported by social leaders, who build the basis of these parties (Carroll 2011). In this sense, the strength of leftist parties, measured in the percentage of votes for leftist parties in city council elections in 2015 (i.e. before the agreement was signed), is an indicator of the presence of credible challengers to established local orders.¹⁴ We expect to observe more assassinations in municipalities in which leftist parties had previously received a greater percentage of votes, i.e. in areas where a more credible challenge exists to local elites.

We also explore if the occurrence and frequency of assassinations is associated with indicators of local competitive authoritarianism. Given that we lack any direct measure for subnational regime types at the municipal level,

¹³We use a negative binomial instead of a poisson model because of the risk of over-dispersion (Cameron and Trivedi 2009).

¹⁴We decided to use “conservative” criteria of what qualifies as a leftist party. We only classified the Unión Patriótica, the Polo Democrático, the Movimiento Alternativo Indígena y Social, and the Alianza Social Independiente as leftist parties. Undoubtedly, center or center-left parties (like the Alianza Verde or even the Liberal Party) have factions that could be classified as “left.” However, given that these parties make alliances and include politicians who are not “left-wing,” it is difficult to establish for each municipality if they are indeed a party of the left.

we turn to two indicators—in the context of Colombian local politics—that plausibly signal (1) limitations on electoral competition and (2) *de facto* restrictions on political participation. In terms of the former, we use the effective number of parties (ENP; Laakso and Taagepera 1979). Strictly speaking, the ENP does not measure the competitiveness of a given political system, but the fragmentation or concentration of the party system. Still, in contexts of multiparty and multicandidate elections as in Colombia, the ENP captures the degree of electoral competition better than traditional margin of victory measures (Uribe 2021).¹⁵ As we know from studies on Colombia's subnational politics, the higher the degree of electoral competition, the more democratic a given local context (Pino Uribe 2018). In line with our argument about competitive authoritarianism, we expect that assassinations are more likely and frequent in municipalities with an intermediate level of party system fragmentation, i.e. when electoral competition over local political power exists but is significantly limited.

To measure local political participation, we use voter turnout at the municipal level as our indicator. While voter turnout is affected by many factors, including the presence of active partisan organizations, local elites and armed groups in Colombia have frequently used intimidation and violence to determine who turns out to vote, thus influencing electoral outcomes (García 2007). Municipalities with low levels of electoral participation, therefore, reasonably indicate the presence of informal practices of subverting democratic participation that are associated with local competitive authoritarianism. Consequently, we should expect more assassinations in municipalities with low turnout.

Local competitive authoritarianism and the targeted violence against social leaders mutually reinforce each other (i.e. there is an endogenous relationship). In line with our theory, it is the very aim of local elites to preserve relatively authoritarian orders that motivates them to use violence against challengers.¹⁶ Thus, violence can potentially lead to even greater limitations in competition and participation. In order to deal with this problem, we use data on ENP and voter turnout from the 2015 municipal elections, i.e. before the current wave of assassinations.

¹⁵The ENP is essentially the same indicator as the commonly used Herfindahl-Hirschman Index to assess electoral competition, but expressed in a more intuitive way. However, we also used an alternative measure of competitiveness as a robustness check in which we measure the difference between the percentage of votes of the first two parties in city council elections. Results using this variable are presented in the [Supplementary Appendix](#), Model A1. Although the variable is not significant, the direction of the relationships is as expected (greater differences between parties, i.e. lower competitiveness, are associated with higher levels of violence).

¹⁶In fact, violence against social leaders is a good predictor of lower turnout rates in elections that occur after the peace agreement was signed, for example, the 2019 municipal elections in Colombia.

Other variables of interest

To measure the impact of illegal economies on the assassination of social leaders we use data from the *Sistema Integrado de Monitoreo de Cultivos Ilícitos* (SIMCI), provided by the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), to measure logged number of hectares of coca cultivation in each municipality in 2016. In addition, based on administrative data of the Colombian government, we measure the logged production of gold in ounces. While our measurement of gold production indicates how much gold was legally produced in a municipality, legal and illegal mining tend to occur side by side. Therefore, legal gold production is a good proxy of illegal mining.

The assassination of social leaders has been associated with the collapse of FARC rebel governance after their demobilization. To determine areas with FARC violent presence before demobilization, we created a dummy variable indicating if the FARC had an active presence in that municipality between 2010 and 2016. Using data from *Violent Presence of Armed Actors in Colombia* (ViPAA) dataset (Osorio et al. 2019), we coded municipalities as having FARC presence when there was at least one registered violent event.¹⁷

The assassination of social leaders has also been linked to the presence of non-state armed groups. To account for the presence of such groups, we also use the ViPPA dataset to create a dummy variable that indicates the presence of multiple NSAGs, when the FARC, other guerrillas, paramilitaries, and criminal groups were present in a municipality. In our robustness checks, we also used ViPPA data to create dummy variables indicating the presence/absence of each type of NSAG in a municipality.

In order to measure state capacity on the subnational level, existing research has employed a variety of indicators. We follow Holmes and Pavon-Harr (2019) in using the Colombian government's Planning Department measure of municipal performance (*medición de desempeño municipal*), a composite index that includes measures of local government taxation and fiscal management, bureaucratic capacity, and ability to provide public goods, including security. The variable ranges from 0 to 100, with 100 being the best possible local state performance. We also use Acemoglu et al. (2020) measure of judicial effectiveness as an indicator of the state's capacity to enforce its own rules for robustness checks.

Conflicts over land also have been linked to the assassination of social leaders (Gutiérrez Sanín et al. 2020). Efforts of land restitution, often spearheaded by social leaders, threaten the economic interests and political

¹⁷Violent presence of the FARC cannot completely account for rebel social orders, as greater forms of control also tend to imply a lower use of violence by rebel groups. In the absence of better data of rebel governance, we use violent presence.

Table 1. Descriptive statistics.

Variable	Obs.	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
<i>DVs</i>					
Assassinations (frequency)	1,123	0.80	2.66	0	44
Assassinations (occurrence)	1,123	0.24*		0	1
<i>IVs and controls</i>					
% Left vote (log)	1,101	2.185	1.29	0.00	4.61
Turnout	1,100	68.09	9.23	3.12	100.00
Effective number of parties	1,100	5.13	1.61	1.37	11.47
State capacity	1,101	72.77	11.57	16.22	92.87
Land restitution	1,008	124.6	251.83	1.00	2,756
FARC presence	1,123	0.24*	–	0	1
Multiple armed groups	1,123	0.12*	–	0	1
Coca cultivation (log)	1,121	0.84	2.09	0.00	9.88
Gold production (log)	1,121	0.61	1.99	0.00	10.98
Homicides (per 1,000)	1,121	0.24	0.32	0.00	3.39
Population (log)	1,121	9.58	1.16	5.97	15.91

*Variables are categorical. The value reported under the mean indicate the proportion of municipalities in which the event occurs.

control of local elites. The assassinations of social leaders can be attempts to “contain” restitution efforts. The number of restitution claims filed in a municipality serves as an indicator of the intensity of land conflicts in a municipality.

Finally, we also use administrative data from the Colombian government to measure the homicide rate per 1,000 inhabitants—as a proxy for the level of violence in the municipality—and population size. Table 1 provides descriptive statistics for all our variables.

Results

Logistic regression

The results of logistic regressions reported in Table 2 provide evidence supporting our hypotheses about the relationship between the presence of bottom-up challenges, as well as the presence of local competitive authoritarianism, and the probability of observing the assassination of a social leader in a municipality.

The share of leftist vote (either as a linear or a squared term) in a municipality in 2015 is positively associated with the probability of later observing the assassination of social leaders. Figure 1 shows this probability is low (close to 0.25) when leftist parties received negligible electoral support. As the share increases, so does the probability of observing assassinations. At the highest observed vote share of the left, our model estimates that the probability of an assassination is close to 0.875.¹⁸ This result provides evidence that in contemporary Colombia, as in the past, the presence of

¹⁸At higher shares of vote for leftist parties we also see bigger confidence intervals. This is likely the result of the low amount of observations for larger vote shares.

Table 2. Regression results.

Variable	Model 1 Logit	Model 2 Logit	Model 3 Negative binomial	Model 4 Negative binomial
% Vote left (log)	0.417*** (0.106)	−0.619 [†] (0.334)	0.455*** (0.075)	−0.702*** (0.226)
% Vote left, log (squared)		0.250** (0.080)		0.272*** (0.052)
Turnout (%)	−0.030** (0.011)	−0.034** (0.012)	−0.026** (0.008)	−0.028*** (0.008)
Effective number of parties (ENP)	−0.144* (0.070)	0.728* (0.324)	−0.205*** (0.045)	0.291 (0.209)
ENP (squared)		−0.072** (0.027)		−0.038* (0.017)
State capacity	−0.006 (0.008)	−0.006 (0.008)	−0.007 (0.006)	−0.006 (0.006)
Land restitution claims	0.001 (0.000)	0.001 (0.000)	0.0002 (0.0002)	0.0003† (0.0002)
FARC violent presence	0.617* (0.251)	0.556* (0.256)	0.578*** (0.171)	0.468** (0.173)
Presence multiple armed actors	0.324 (0.312)	0.425 (0.318)	0.354† (0.184)	0.435* (0.183)
Coca in hectares (log)	0.257*** (0.045)	0.238*** (0.046)	0.150*** (0.025)	0.135*** (0.025)
Gold production (log)	−0.031 (0.041)	−0.03 (0.042)	0.025 (0.024)	0.033 (0.024)
Homicide rate (per 1000 residents)	1.294*** (0.287)	1.358*** (0.285)	1.257*** (0.152)	1.276*** (0.152)
Population (log)	0.819*** (0.118)	0.885*** (0.124)	0.672*** (0.070)	0.724*** (0.071)
Constant	−8.062*** (1.542)	−10.1*** (1.862)	−6.262*** (1.009)	−7.300*** (1.176)
N	993	993	993	993
AIC	797.531	787.693	1748.919	1726.497

[†] $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.0011$; standard errors in parenthesis.

credible challengers to existing authoritarian orders at the local level contributes to unleashing episodes of violent repression.

Moreover, as [Figure 2](#) illustrates, intermediate levels of fragmentation of the municipal party system (i.e. an effective number of parties between 4 and 5), are associated with a higher probability of observing an assassination in a municipality. Lower probabilities are observed both with higher fragmentation and extremely low levels of fragmentation. These results indicate that lethal violence against social leaders is more likely when there is limited electoral competition, i.e. contexts in which local politicians can credibly fear to lose, but less likely when they have full control or when competition is thoroughly fragmented.¹⁹ Meanwhile, the most fragmented systems, presumably more democratic, and the most closed ones exhibit lower levels of lethal violence.

¹⁹While in other contexts an ENP of 4 or 5 might indicate a significant number of competitive parties, in many Colombian municipalities, parties are little more than legal requirements. Often hegemonic political machines control several party labels as a way to guarantee a greater number of seats, thus inducing a great level of fragmentation (i.e. an ENP of 4 or 5) that does not necessarily reflect greater political competition (Albarracín and Milanese 2021).

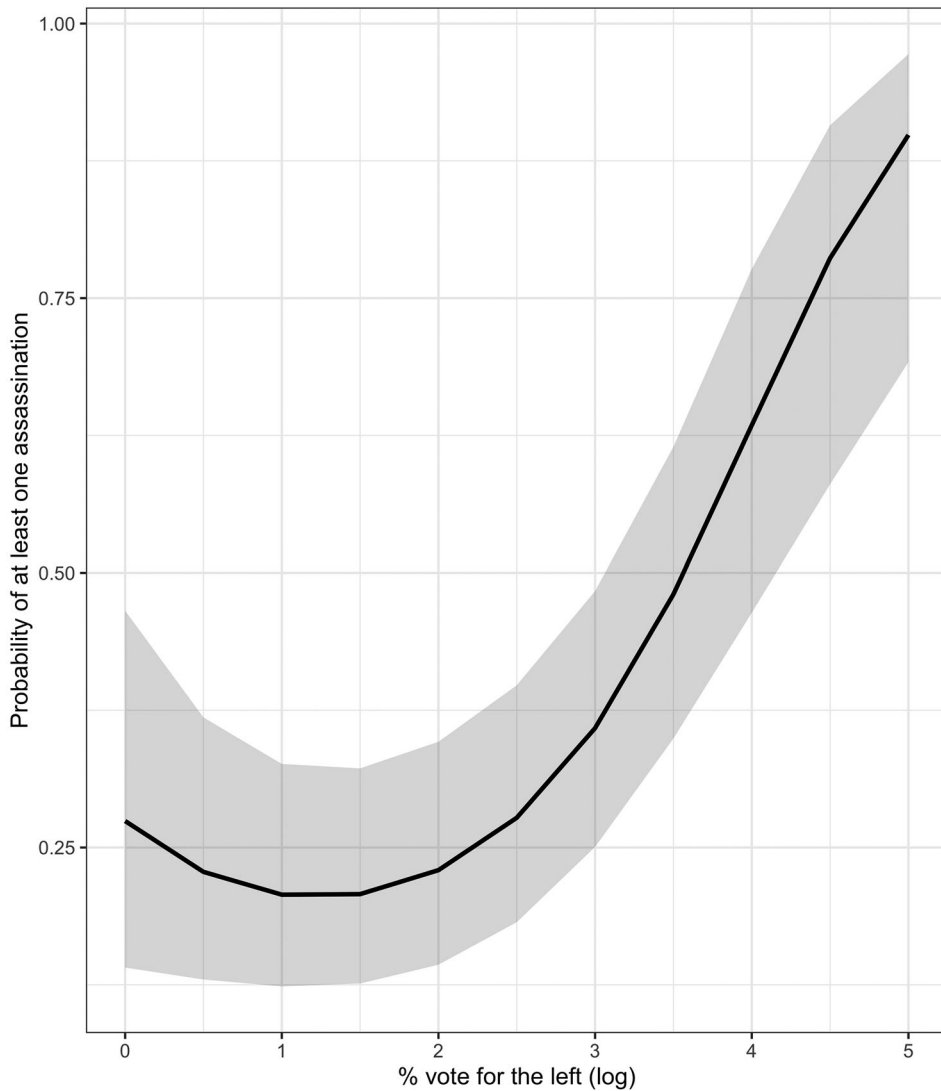


Figure 1. Share of leftist vote and the probability of an assassination.

As expected, the probability of assassinations is also higher in municipalities with low voter turnout, i.e. with restricted electoral participation (Figure 3). This lends further support to the argument that local competitive authoritarianism contributes to the targeted violence against social leaders.

The results of the logistic regression also provide evidence in support of the conventional explanation, which emphasizes the collapse of rebel governance and the role of illicit economies. Our models indicate that areas in which the FARC had a violent presence between 2010 and 2016 are more likely to experience lethal violence against social leaders in the aftermath of their demobilization. As we discussed previously, these are likely

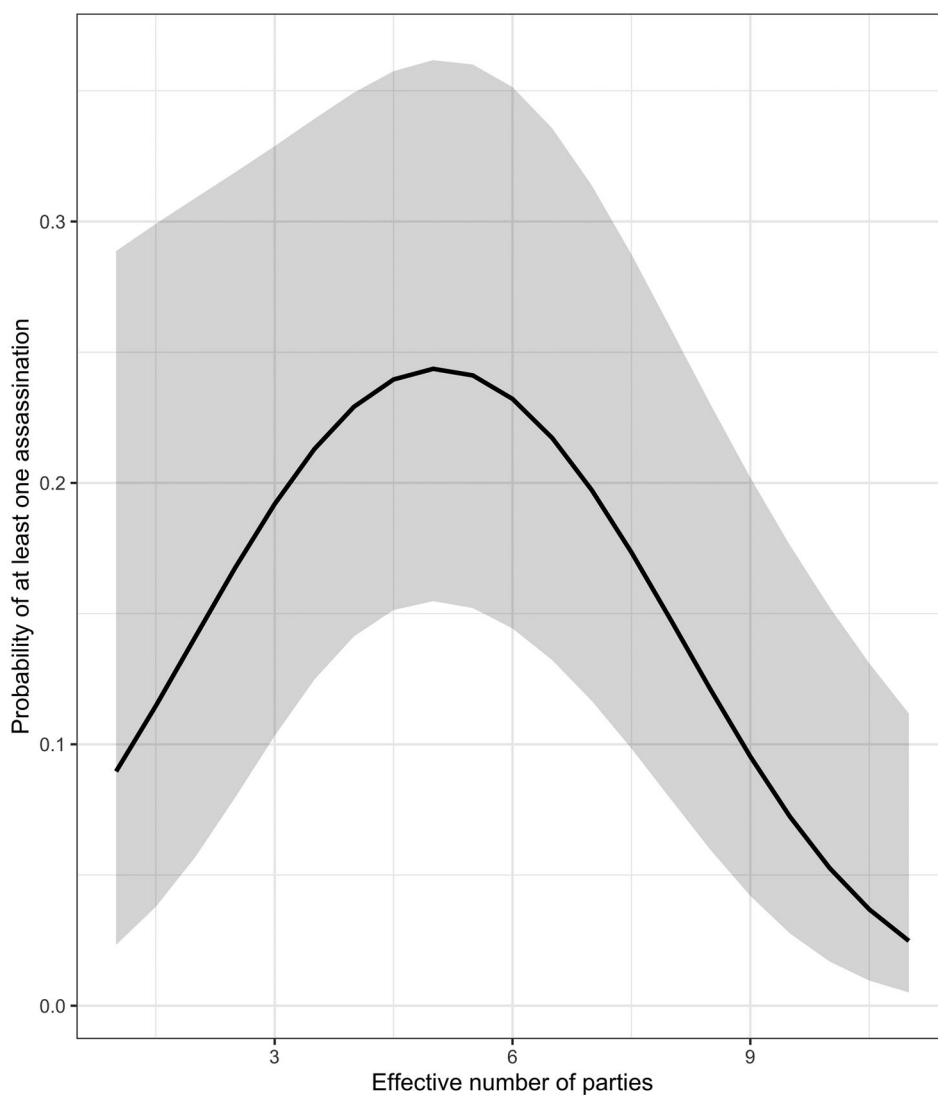


Figure 2. Effective number of parties and probability of an assassination.

municipalities in which the withdrawal of the FARC has led to local power vacuums and territorial struggles to establish new social and political orders. With a view to illicit markets, we find evidence linking coca cultivation to the assassination of social leaders. Higher levels of violent crime (as measured by the homicide rate) also are positively related to assassinations.

In contrast, the presence of other non-state armed actors (paramilitaries, other guerrillas, and criminal groups) and the level of municipal state capacity²⁰ is not significantly associated with the assassination of social leaders.

²⁰This applies for the models using the index of municipal performance, as well as the models available in Table A2 of the [Supplementary Appendix](#) which use the index of judicial effectiveness.

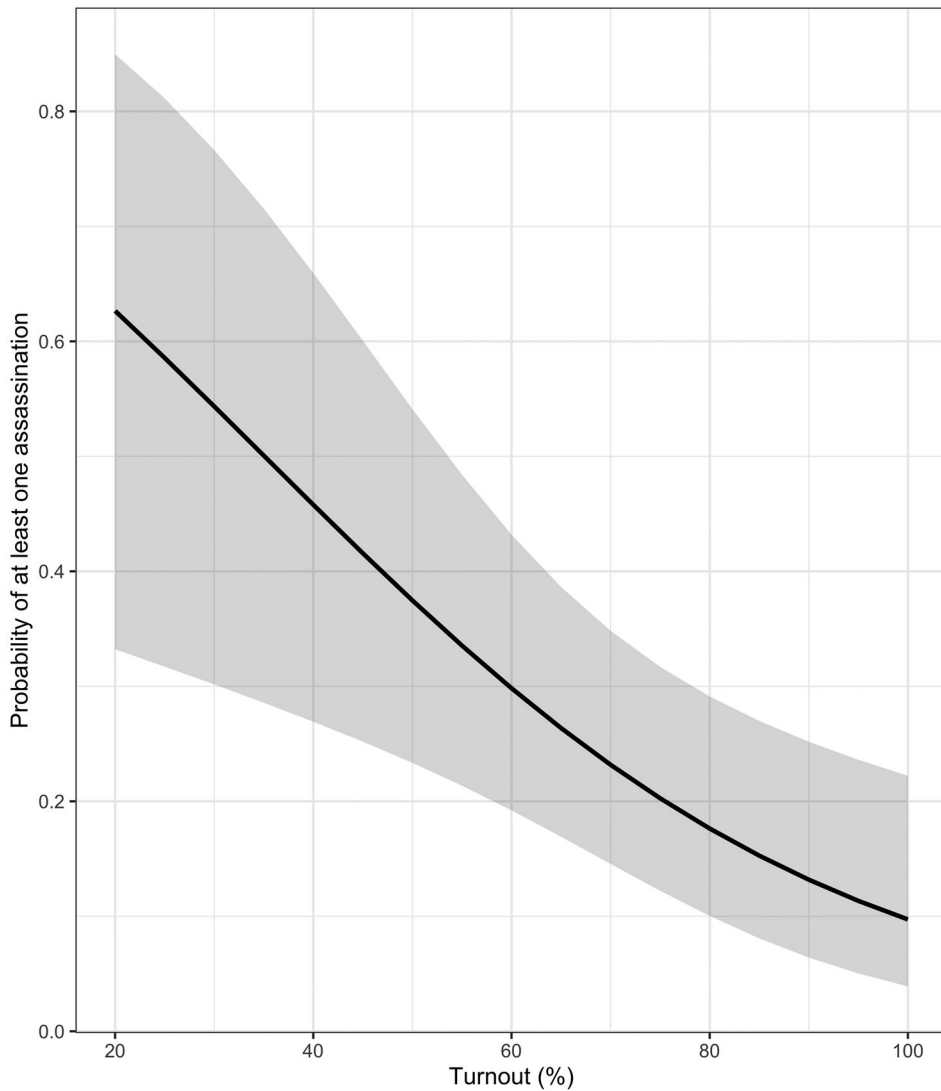


Figure 3. Turnout and the probability of an assassination.

These results and similar results of the count models by no means indicate that state capacity and the presence of armed groups are irrelevant factors. As suggested by Holmes and Pavon-Harr (2019), who report a similar non-finding, overall state capacity may simply be too general a measure, failing to grasp the more specific presence and operation of state institutions. Furthermore, in causal terms, limited state capacity can be seen as a factor that enables, but in and of itself does not cause the use of targeted violence against social leaders in a given local setting. There may well be municipalities with low state capacity, but where neither local competitive authoritarianism, nor significant bottom-up challenges, nor relevant illicit economies and related NSAGs exist. In this sense, rather than focusing on the

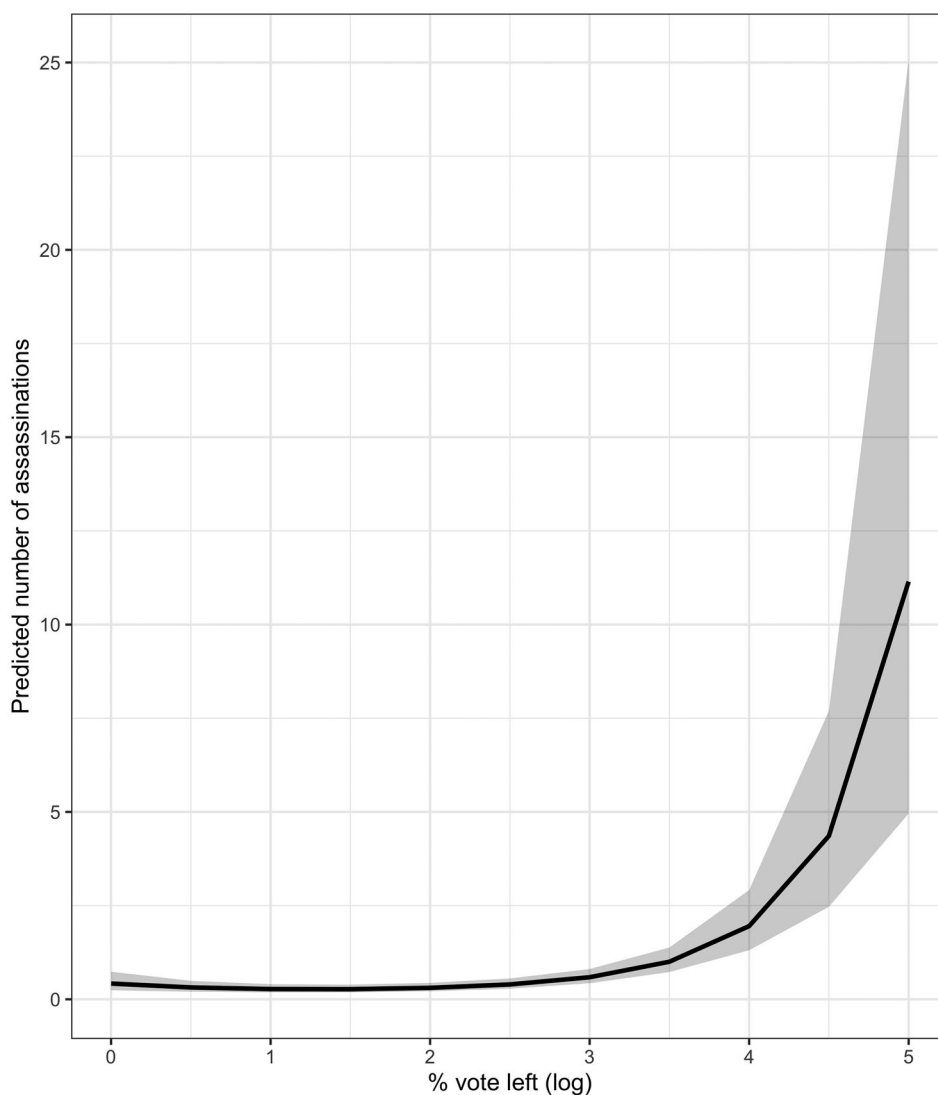


Figure 4. Share of leftist vote and predicted assassination count.

presence or the capacity of the Colombian state in general, it is probably more promising to explore when and how limited state capacity combines with other factors to cause the assassination of social leaders.

Negative binomial model

The results of our negative binomial regression also reported in [Table 2](#) provide further confirmation for our argument. As in the logit model, the percentage of leftist vote is positively associated with the frequency of violence. This relationship is also quadratic: As [Figure 4](#) illustrates, low and intermediate vote shares of leftist parties in city council elections are

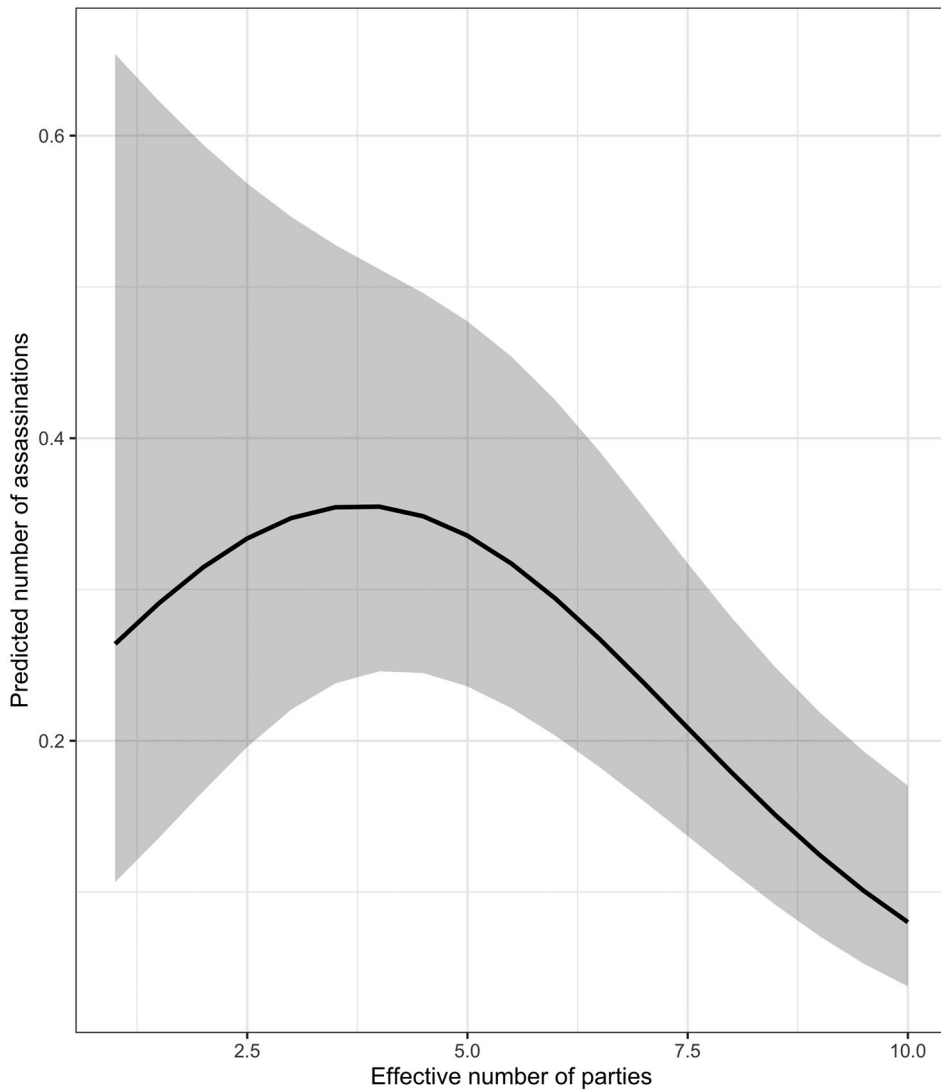


Figure 5. Effective number of parties and predicted assassination count.

associated with low levels of lethal violence against social leaders. However, once the left becomes a credible challenger to local elites, the frequency of assassinations increases exponentially.

The effective number of parties also exhibits a quadratic association with the frequency of lethal violence against social leaders. As shown in [Figure 5](#), intermediate levels of the effective number of parties have a higher predicted count of assassinations. The predicted number of assassinations, however, declines sharply once the ENP approximates 3.75. Electoral turnout also shows a negative effect. The predicted number of assassinations for a municipality in which 20% voted is about 1.1, in contrast to 0.14 for a municipality with 100% turnout ([Figure 6](#)).

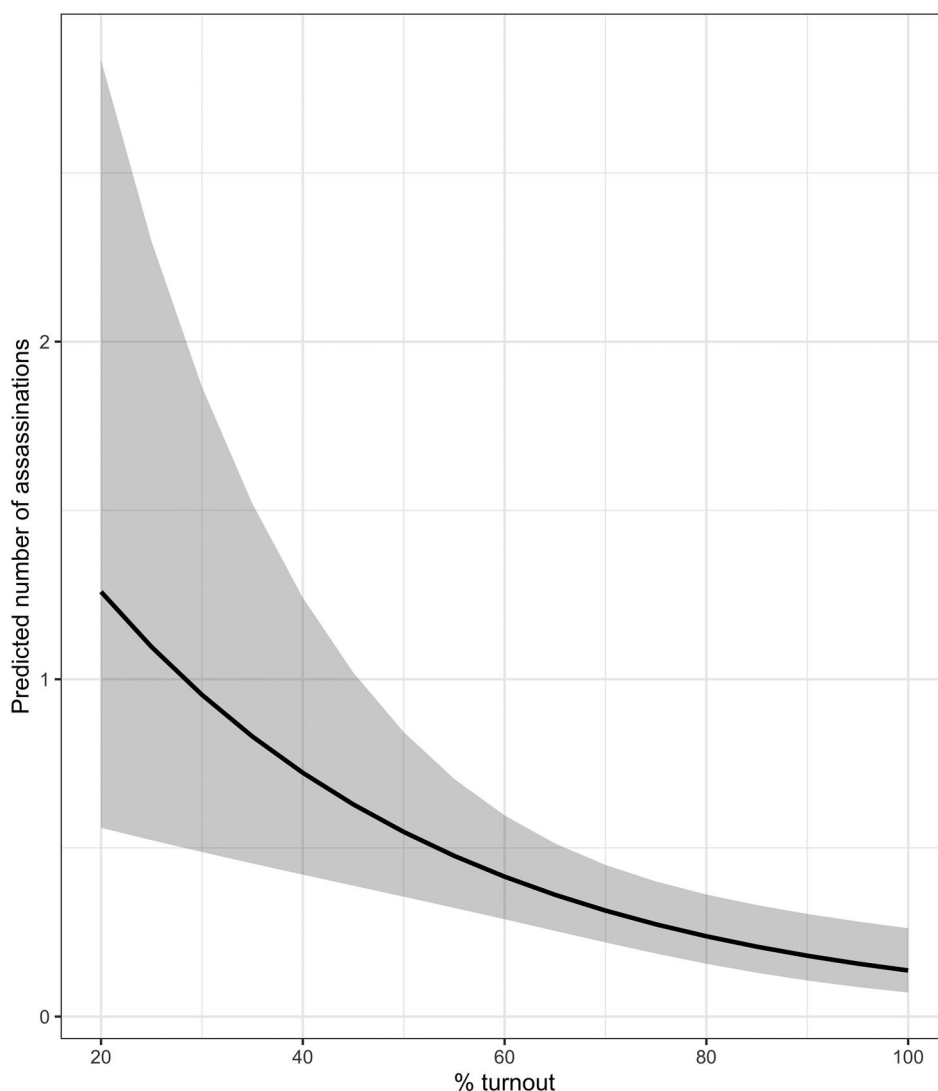


Figure 6. Turnout and predicted assassination count.

Conclusions

The assassination of social leaders in post-conflict Colombia endangers the construction of peace in territories that have been hit the hardest by armed conflict. Moreover, it continues a tragic tradition in Colombia at times of “peace” in which human rights defenders and local socio-political leaders are disproportionately victimized. Unfortunately, it is not surprising that the implementation of the 2016 peace agreement has come with high levels of lethal violence against these activists.

The aim of this article was to build on conventional explanations of post-conflict violence that focus—not only in Colombia—on illicit

economies and criminal groups and, thereby, emphasize its allegedly unpolitical nature (Kurtenbach and Rettberg 2018, 1-2). By drawing our attention to the relationship between targeted lethal violence against social leaders and the logic of local political orders, we highlighted the explicitly political nature that characterizes at least part of the post-conflict violence in contemporary Colombia. Applying the concept of competitive authoritarianism to the subnational level, we have argued that local elites use lethal violence to sustain formally democratic, but factually authoritarian orders in the face of bottom-up challenges to their power. The assassination of social leaders, thus, is not only about the control of illicit economies. It is also about the sociopolitical control of Colombia's rural and peripheral territories, perpetuating the historical process of "differential" state building in Colombia (González and Otero 2010).

Our empirical analysis using cross-sectional data of all Colombian municipalities supports this argument. More democratic municipalities are less likely to experience lethal violence against community leaders. At the same time, we are more likely to observe the assassination of social leaders in municipalities in which the left is stronger electorally, i.e. where a credible bottom-up challenge to local elites exists. This does not mean that the combination of thriving illicit economies and competing NSAGs is not an important factor behind the current wave of targeted assassinations of social leaders in Colombia. We find, for example, that violence is more prevalent in areas in which the FARC was present before its demobilization, i.e. in contexts in which the power vacuum following this group's demobilization plausibly unleashed violent struggles over territorial control (Prem et al. 2021). Yet, as we show, focusing on illegal groups and criminal structures alone is not sufficient to understand this type of post-conflict violence. It is necessary to also incorporate the decidedly political dimension of the phenomenon at hand, that is, the working of local political orders and the ways in which these have been challenged.

By emphasizing the role of local politics in post-conflict violence, our study makes important contributions that can transcend the case of Colombia. Often studies on post-conflict violence and peacebuilding focus on national level changes, for example, the implementation of security sector reforms and state building (e.g. Paris 2004), the impact of past violence (e.g. Deglow 2016), or overall reforms to democratize the political regime (e.g. Matanock 2017). While these fundamental reforms can reduce the likelihood of post-conflict violence, they do not address forms of violence that result from local politics. Including local political orders in our analysis enables us to better understand patterns of post-conflict violence.

While circumscribed to the Colombian case, our study suggests that, beyond the dynamics of illicit markets, part of this violence results from efforts to

curtail local political competition. The particularities of the Colombian case, such as the peculiar history of decades of armed conflict in the context of a formally democratic regime at the national level, imply that our more specific findings do not necessarily translate to other cases. Generally speaking, the nature of local elites, their challengers, as well as the specific characteristics of subnational authoritarianism will certainly vary by context. However, our general framework can be potentially useful to understand decentralized forms of organized violence, in post-conflict settings but plausibly also whenever the mobilization and empowerment of previously marginalized groups elicit violent backlashes by established local elites that seek to perpetuate their exclusionary political rule at the subnational level. Of course, the assassination of social leaders is not the only means by which such elites can respond to changes in local power balances. Their ability to use targeted violence as well as its (perceived) appropriateness and effectiveness will vary according to both local and national context conditions.

In line with the suggestion from a study on the assassination of environmental and land defenders, we need more “spatially disaggregated analyses” (Le Billon and Lujala 2020, 11) in order to systematically assess the role of subnational political orders as well as the precise causal mechanisms and scope conditions. Brazil and Mexico, the Latin American cases with the highest numbers of assassinations of environmental and land defenders, might display logics that are roughly similar to the Colombian case, given the prevalence of forms of subnational authoritarianism and its links to organized violence (Trejo and Ley 2020). Further research will have to assess whether the presence of local authoritarian orders, as in Colombia, helps explain the occurrence of decentralized violence against social activists in these and other cases.

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Ethical approval

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ORCID

Juan Albarracín  <http://orcid.org/0000-0001-8375-3427>

Juan Pablo Milanese  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-0980-3435>

Inge H. Valencia  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1028-9891>

Jonas Wolff  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-7348-7206>

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